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A Great Commission Church

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A Great Commission Church

Jesus' last command to His disciples was to "go and make disciples of all nations" (Matthew 28:19). After Pentecost, His followers obediently began the process of world evangelization, known as the Great Commission.

When the apostle Paul was called by Jesus to proclaim the gospel to the Gentiles, he established local churches as the primary means of accomplishing the Great Commission.

The Supreme Task of the Church

Dr. Oswald J. Smith, founding pastor of The People's Church in Toronto, Canada, asked, "What is the supreme task of the church?" In his classic book *The Cry of the World*, he answered:

The supreme task of the Church is the evangelization of the world. I believe that with all my heart. The most important work of the Church of Jesus Christ is world evangelization.

Unfortunately, the statistics show that such Great Commission churches are few. A Great Commission church keeps its primary focus on Jesus' mandate to make disciples of all nations — passionately advancing the Gospel and equipping believers to reach the world.

When he traveled to Israel, Smith observed the stark contrast between the Sea of Galilee, teeming with life, and the Dead Sea, stagnant and lifeless. The Sea of Galilee had both an inlet and an outlet, keeping its water fresh, whereas the Dead Sea had no outlet. He writes:

There you have a perfect illustration of the missionary church and the church that is not interested in missions. The latter takes in, but it uses everything on itself ... it is filled, like a stagnant pool, with criticism, gossip, fault-finding, division and strife. The missionary church takes in, but it also gives out ... it is alive and aggressive, and God's blessing rests upon it.

Mission Must Remain the Priority

Some reason, “We must first reach our local community with the gospel, and once they’re evangelized, we can focus on reaching the world.” This is a fair point, backed by a Scriptural example. The Gospel was first proclaimed in Jerusalem, then spread to Judea, Samaria, and the rest of the Roman Empire.

However, the Holy Spirit did not wait for Jerusalem to be saturated with the Gospel before sending the disciples out to Judea and Samaria (Acts 8:1). The emphasis of Acts 1:8 is that Jesus’ disciples were called to be His witnesses everywhere — both near and far. Its vision is that the concentric circles of gospel impact are to reach the entire world.

Smith speaks to this issue:

When Jesus left His disciples ... He gave them but one task; namely, world evangelization ... Jesus never told us to build colleges, universities, and seminaries, but we have done it ... And we ought to have done it, because it is all important and worthwhile. But the one and only thing that He did tell us to do is the one and only thing that we have left undone. We have not given His Gospel to the entire world. We have not carried out His orders.

Smith points out that missions should not be delegated to a small group within the church, but should be the focus of every person — beginning with the head pastor, elders, deacons, and staff. In other words, missions should not be shoved into a corner or treated as just another ministry; it should be embraced as the DNA of the entire church.

A Great Commission Church’s Budget

Where your treasure is, there will your heart be also.

— Matthew 6:21

When Dr. Smith began his ministry at The People’s Church, he was committed to aligning its budget with the vision of reaching the world for Christ. Yet his auditor revealed that the church was in debt. As Smith began communicating the Great Commission vision from the pulpit, giving increased. A few years later, 85% of the

church's annual budget was sent to support world missions; only 15% was spent on church expenses. Smith's goal was to increase missions giving to 90% of the total budget — just the opposite of the average church, which allocates only 10–15% to missions.

How a Local Church Can Participate

So how does a local church participate in fulfilling Jesus' Great Commission? Here are a few practical ways:

- Preach on the Great Commission frequently from the pulpit.
- Create or support local evangelistic outreach.
- Send missionaries to other countries.
- Invite missionaries to speak during the service regularly.
- Add a short segment on global missions in weekly worship services.
- Reach out to immigrants in your community.
- Partner with organizations committed to world missions.
- Pray for the world to be reached for Christ.
- Equip church members in global missions (e.g., a course such as Perspectives).

Although Oswald J. Smith has gone to his reward in Heaven, he leaves behind a Great Commission-focused church that has not only reached millions for Christ but still follows his example of obedience to Jesus' words: "Go into all the world and make disciples of all nations."

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